Lesson 32

Unemployment

"Commit to the LORD whatever you do,
and your plans will succeed."
(Proverbs 16:3)

Unemployed: without a job; out of work

In today's economy, many people are out of work or are in jobs that they don't want or like. If you are feeling lost or fearful, turn God for help and guidance. Seek His will for your life and do not give up hope.

Synopsis

If you are a Christian, realize that God has a plan for your life. His plan is for you to prosper and to stay out of harm's way—to give you hope and a future.[1] Your current situation may appear disastrous and you may be feeling desperate. However, remember that your problems are not too big for the creator of the universe and no matter what has happened, all things (even unemployment) can be used by God for your benefit.[2]

If you currently have a job, even one that in your eyes is not very desirable, you should give thanks to God and consider remaining

"For I know the plans I have for you," declares the LORD,
"plans to prosper you and not to harm you,
plans to give you hope and a future."
(Jeremiah 29:11)[1]

And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him, who have been called according to his purpose.
(Romans 8:28)[2]

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in your current employment until God opens up another door.[3] It may be that God wants you to stay in your situation until he calls you do something else.[4]

Whatever your job, work at it with all your heart, as if you were working for the Lord and not for man.[5] Remember that there are many different ways that you can serve God.[6,7] Try not to compare your job to that of others,[8] and take comfort in the fact that all hard work brings a profit.[9]

If you are currently unemployed, try not to become lazy.[10,11] Laziness typically leads to poverty.[12]

Brothers, each man, as responsible to God,
should remain in the situation God called him to.
(1 Corinthians 7:24)[3]

As long as it is day, we must do the work of him who sent me.
Night is coming, when no one can work.
(John 9:4)[4]

Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord, not for men, since you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as a reward.
(Colossians 3:23-24)[5]

There are different kinds of service, but the same Lord.
(1 Corinthians 12:5)[6]

There are different kinds of working,
but the same God works all of them in all men.
(1 Corinthians 12:6)[7]

Each one should test his own actions. Then he can take pride in himself, without comparing himself to somebody else,
for each one should carry his own load.
(Galatians 6:4-5)[8]

All hard work brings a profit,
but mere talk leads only to poverty.
(Proverbs 14:23)[9]

The fool folds his hands and ruins himself.
(Ecclesiastes 4:5)[10]

Finally, if you are out of work, try not to chase fantasies and "get rich quick" schemes.[13] Such schemes often lead to grief, ruin, and destruction.[14,15]

God's Guidance

Being out of work or not making enough money to support yourself and/or your family can be an extremely anxiety provoking. However, God does not want us to live in fear.[16-19] Your Heavenly Father

Lazy hands make a man poor,
but diligent hands bring wealth.
(Proverbs 10:4)[11]

A little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands
to rest—and poverty will come on you like a bandit
and scarcity like an armed man.
(Proverbs 6:10-11)[12]

He who works his land will have abundant food,
but he who chases fantasies lacks judgment.
(Proverbs 12:11)[13]

Some people, eager for money, have wandered from the faith
and pierced themselves with many griefs.
(1 Timothy 6:10)[14]

People who want to get rich fall into temptation and a trap
and into many foolish and harmful desires that plunge
men into ruin and destruction.
(1 Timothy 6:9)[15]

Do not let your hearts be troubled and do not be afraid.
(John 14:17)[16]

Don't be afraid, just believe.
(Mark 5:36)[17]

The Lord is my helper; I will not be afraid.
(Hebrews 13:6)[18]

God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in trouble.
(Psalm 46:1)[19]

Your Father knows what you need before you ask him.
(Matthew 6:8)[20]

is completely aware of all your needs.[20,21] He encourages us to trust in him[22] and turn to Him in prayer.[23-25] We are to present our requests to Him, and find the peace that comes with turning everything over to God.[26] Our Lord promises that He will never let the righteous fall,[27] and that He will provide for our basic needs of food and clothing.[21,28]

If you are unemployed, one of the of the best things you can do is to totally submit *your* will, to *God's* will.[29] Stop trying to figure everything out using your own limited brain and reasoning abilities.

So do not worry, saying "What shall we eat?" or "What shall we drink?" or "What shall we wear?" For the pagans run after all these things, and your heavenly Father knows that you need them.
(Matthew 6:31-32)[21]

When I am afraid, I will trust in you.
(Psalm 56:3)[22]

Is any one of you in trouble? He should pray.
(James 5:13)[23]

The prayer of a righteous man is powerful and effective.
(James 5:16)[24]

If you believe, you will receive whatever you ask for in prayer.
(Matthew 21:22)[25]

Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which transcends all under-standing, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.
(Philippians 4:6-7)[26]

Cast your cares on the LORD and he will sustain you; he will never let the righteous fall.
(Psalm 55:22)[27]

Consider the lilies of the field, how they grow; they neither toil nor spin, yet I tell you, even Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these.
(Matthew 6:28-29)[28]

Submit yourselves, then, to God.
(James 4:7)[29]

The situation is probably much bigger and more complicated than your own limited capacity to make sense of things.[30-33] Just turn things over to God, let go of all fear and anxiety, and let God help you find your path and direction in life.[34]

In the final analysis, being unemployed, may turn out to be the best thing that ever happened to you. In your weakness,[35,36] you

His wisdom is profound, his power is vast.
(Job 9:4)[30]

Great is our Lord and mighty in power;
his understanding has no limit.
(Psalm 147:5)[31]

"For my thoughts are not your thoughts,
neither are your ways my ways," declares the LORD.
(Isaiah 55:8)[32]

Where is the wise man? Where is the scholar? Where is the philosopher of this age? Has not God made foolish the wisdom of the world?
(1 Corinthians 1:20)[33]

Trust in the LORD with all you heart and lean not on your own understanding; in all you ways acknowledge him, and he will make your paths straight.
(Proverbs 3:5-6)[34]

For when I am weak, then I am strong.
(2 Corinthians 12:10)[35]

The LORD upholds all those who fall
and lifts up all who are bowed down.
(Psalm 145:14)[36]

Look to the LORD and his strength;
seek his face always.
(Psalm 105:4)[37]

I can do everything through him who gives me strength.
(Philippians 4:13)[38]

may choose to look to God and his strength,[37,38] and seek his will for your life.[39,40] In your hopelessness, you may turn to God and find hope.[41-43]

Finally, remember that God's plan for your life may not be the plan that you have always had in mind.[44-46] In fact, this may be the perfect time to turn back to God and seek His will for your life.[39] If you are doing what God has chosen for you to do, your plans will always succeed.[47]

Teach me to do your will, for you are my God;
may your good Spirit lead me on level ground.
(Psalm 143:10)[39]

Your will be done on earth as it is in heaven.
(Matthew 6:10)[40]

Anyone who is among the living has hope.
(Ecclesiastes 9:4)[41]

Sustain me according to your promise, and I will live;
do not let my hopes be dashed.
(Psalm 119:116)[42]

May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace
as you trust in him, so that you may overflow with hope
by the power of the Holy Spirit.
(Romans 15:13)[43]

In his heart a man plans his course,
but the LORD determines his steps.
(Proverbs 16:9)[44]

Many are the plans in a man's heart,
but it is the LORD'S purpose that prevails.
(Proverbs 19:21)[45]

There is no wisdom, no insight, no plan
that can succeed against the LORD.
(Proverbs 21:30)[46]

Commit to the LORD whatever you do,
and your plans will succeed.
(Proverbs 16:3)[47]